

Cold Read: Game Plan

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The game at a glance

Cold Read is a free, dark detective game where each level is one murder case, solved with real investigation skills. It is inspired by the style of *The Mentalist*, but every character, place and story is original.

The game has a purpose beyond fun. Players train three real skills:

- **Noticing details** that others overlook
- **Connecting the dots** between evidence, people and time
- **Reading human behaviour**: lies, body language, motives

Decision	What we chose
Player	Julian Marsh, a former TV psychic who now consults for the police
Helpers	A by-the-book police partner, plus a tech expert reached by phone
Setting	Port Halden, an invented harbour city
Tone	Dark and serious
Crime scenes	Realistic but restrained: the victim is shown, no close-up gore
Look	Realistic documents and evidence, illustrated people and places
Solving a case	Build the full case: killer, motive, method and key evidence
Waiting	In-game clock; results arrive as you investigate
Hints	Earned through good detective work; they point where to look, never the answer
Wrong case	The wrong person is charged, with story consequences; the case can be reopened with a changed trail

Decision	What we chose
Learning	A debrief after each case: what you found, what you missed, the real technique
Structure	1 case per level, 10 cases per chapter, 3–4 connected cases per chapter
Platforms	Phone and computer, in the browser first
Language	English
Access	Free, with a login that saves progress
Budget	Close to zero to start
Case writing	The team writes; the owner reviews and approves

World and characters

All cases happen in one invented city, so players learn its streets, people and secrets over time. Names below other than Cold Read, Julian Marsh and Port Halden are proposals for you to approve or change.

Port Halden

A grey harbour city where old money and dirty docks sit side by side. Cases are handled by the **Port Halden Police Department, Major Crimes Unit**.

District	Feel	Typical cases
Old Town	Narrow streets, old families, antique shops	Inheritance, long-buried secrets
The Docks	Shipping yards, night shifts, warehouses	Smuggling, debts, workplace deaths
Hillcrest	Gated homes, private clubs	Affairs, fraud, staged accidents
Eastgate	Struggling, close-knit neighbourhood	Gangs, revenge, wrongful suspicion
Financial Quarter	Glass towers, late offices	Corporate crime, blackmail

The team

- **Julian Marsh (the player).** A famous TV psychic whose act was a trick: he read people from tiny clues and paid researchers to dig up private details. He quit after one show went badly wrong. Now he consults for Major Crimes, using the same skills to catch liars.
- **Detective Sergeant Lena Cruz (the partner).** By the book, sharp and sceptical of Julian's methods. She handles warrants, arrests and procedure, and gives the earned hints. Their friction gives the dark story some human warmth.
- **Theo Park (the tech expert).** Reached by phone or message. He pulls phone records, camera footage, bank activity and background checks. Each case's special tools come through him.

The thread behind the connected cases

On Julian's final show, he "revealed" a private secret about a woman in the audience, using information his researchers had found. Weeks later she was found dead, and it was ruled suicide. Julian never believed it.

In each chapter, 3–4 cases carry quiet traces of someone who learned Julian's methods and uses them to manipulate people into crime. Players slowly realise one hidden figure links them. A working name for this figure is **the Stagehand**, because they stay out of sight and move people like props.

This thread is deliberately different from the show's villain. There is no calling-card symbol and no attack on Julian's family, so the story stays clearly original.

How a case plays

Every case follows the same arc: a shocking opening, a full case file, an open investigation across the city, a twist halfway, and a final case the player must prove.

1. **The opening.** A short scene made of moving pictures, sound and text, such as a 911 call over a security-camera still, or a news report. Then a brief description of what happened.
2. **The case file.** The victim's profile, crime scene photos, the first police report, the map, and the first list of people to see.
3. **The investigation.** The player moves freely, in any order:
 - **Crime scene:** zoom into photos, mark details, revisit later to spot what changed or was missed
 - **People:** visit family, friends and coworkers; choose questions; watch reactions and answers

- **Places:** the victim's home, workplace and the places from their last two days
 - **Timeline:** rebuild where the victim was the day before and on the day itself
 - **Evidence board:** pin evidence, people and times, and link them
 - **Notebook:** free notes, plus automatic notes of every statement heard
 - **Requests to Theo:** phone records, camera footage, bank activity, background checks
4. **The in-game clock.** Every visit or interview moves time forward. Lab results and records arrive after enough time passes, and some people are only available at certain hours.
 5. **Signs of progress.** When the player finds something that truly matters: a "Lead confirmed" stamp, a new place or person unlocks, the case meter fills, or Lena reacts. Nothing appears for wrong turns, so progress cannot be faked.
 6. **The twist.** About halfway, something changes the picture: a second victim, a broken alibi, a lying witness, or a secret the victim was hiding.
 7. **Building the case.** The player presents the killer, the motive, the method and the key evidence. All four must hold up.
 8. **The verdict and debrief.** A correct case closes with the confession scene and the debrief. A wrong case has consequences (see the next section).

Questioning people starts as chosen questions, which are reliable and free to run. Typed questions answered by AI may be tested later, once costs and safety are clear.

Difficulty, consequences and learning

The game should be hard but always fair: every answer can be reached from evidence in the case, and nothing depends on luck or guessing.

Earned hints

Players earn hints by finding key evidence, solving side puzzles (a coded note, a locked phone, a torn receipt) or spotting small details. A hint points where to look, never at the answer.

- **Not this:** "The neighbour is lying about the time."
- **But this:** "Look again at what the neighbour said they heard, and when."

A wrong case

If the case does not hold up, the wrong person is charged and the real killer stays free. The story remembers: the real killer may strike again, a family may refuse to talk next time, or the mistake may return in a later case.

The case is not closed forever. The player can **reopen** it, but the trail changes, so replaying is a new investigation:

Reopened case type	What changes	Used for	Extra work
Same killer, different trail	The truth stays; key clues and leads change	Most cases	About 1.5× per case
Different killer	Another suspect is guilty; clues are rebuilt	Chapter finales and connected cases	About 2–3× per case

The debrief

After every solved case, a short review shows:

- what the player found and **what they missed**
- **the real technique** behind each key clue, explained simply (for example, *baseline behaviour*: noticing when someone's normal habits change)
- one tip to use in real life, such as "When someone over-explains a simple answer, ask yourself why."

The techniques should be checked by someone with real investigation experience before launch, because the game promises real skills.

Look, rating and platforms

The game mixes realistic paperwork with illustrated people and places, so documents feel real and characters stay consistent across scenes.

- **Realistic:** police reports, statements, receipts, phone logs, bank records, maps, photos of objects and evidence
- **Illustrated:** people, crime scenes, rooms and streets, in one consistent dark graphic-novel style
- **Openings:** moving pictures with sound and text, such as camera stills, a news report or a voicemail, rather than filmed video
- **Crime scenes:** the victim, the scene, the location, a map and the surroundings are all shown; no close-up gore
- **Rating:** older teens and adults, likely 16+ or 17+ in app stores, with an age check at sign-up
- **Platforms:** a browser game that works on phones and computers. Computers get a wide case board; phones get a one-hand layout with zoom on evidence

- **Login:** free account by email or Google; progress saves and carries across devices
- **Language:** English

Structure and scope

The goal of 10 chapters (100 cases) stays, but the game launches with Chapter 1 and grows chapter by chapter. Writing 100 fair, detailed cases before anyone plays would take too long and risk building the wrong thing.

Inside a chapter

Case	Type
1, 2, 4, 5, 7, 9	Standalone cases
3, 6, 8	Connected: quiet traces of the same hidden figure
10	Chapter finale: the connected thread pays off, and a new question opens for the next chapter

Difficulty rises through the chapter. Early cases teach the tools; later cases hide clues deeper and use more twists.

How each case is made and approved

1. **Game Designer and Narrative Designer** write the crime, characters, timeline, clues and twist.
2. **Psychologist** checks that suspects' behaviour, lies and reactions are realistic.
3. **Historian, Geographer or other specialists** check details when a case needs them.
4. **Reality Checker** plays it through and confirms it is hard but fair, with no unsolvable or obvious parts.
5. **You** read a one-page summary and approve, ask for changes, or reject it.
6. **Builders** put the approved case into the game, and **Evidence Collector** tests it on phone and computer.

Budget and tools

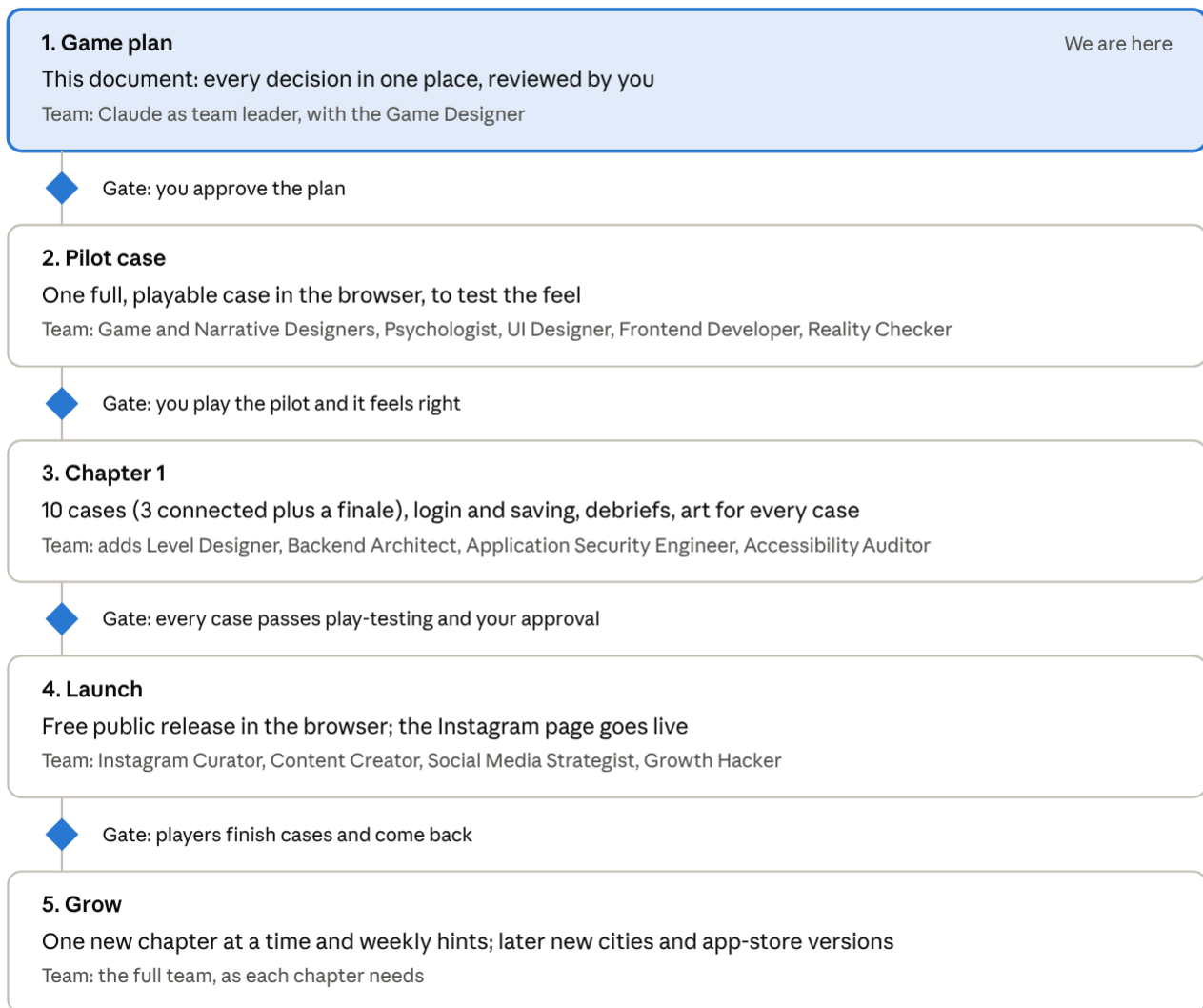
The pilot case and Chapter 1 can be built and launched at close to zero cost. Pictures are the main area where money would make a real difference later.

Item	Cost to start	Notes
Building the game	Free	Done by Claude and the agent team
Hosting the game online	Free	Free website hosting, such as GitHub Pages, gives a public link
Login and saved progress	Free	Free plans of standard login services cover the first several thousand players
Pictures and illustrations	Free, limited	Free AI image tools have daily limits; keeping faces consistent takes care. The biggest quality risk at zero budget
Opening scenes	Free	Moving pictures, sound effects and text instead of filmed video
Sound effects and music	Free	Free-licence sound libraries
Instagram	Free	Posts made from the game's own art
Own web address	About \$10–15 a year	Optional; the free link works
App Store and Google Play	About \$99 a year (Apple) + \$25 once (Google)	Only when moving beyond the browser version
AI-answered questioning	Paid per use	Only if tested later; not part of the launch plan

Roadmap

The game is built in five phases, and each one starts only after you approve the one before. No dates are set yet; the pilot case comes right after this plan is approved.

Each phase starts only after the one before passes its gate



Cold Read roadmap · 5 phases, 4 gates

The pilot is the most important gate: playing a real case shows what works long before 10 cases are built.

Instagram and launch

The Instagram page starts before launch to build curiosity, then becomes the weekly home for hints. You create the account and post; the marketing agents (Instagram Curator, Content Creator, Social Media Strategist) plan and write everything.

Before launch

- Claim the name, for example **@coldreadgame** (to check if it is free)
- Profile in the game's dark style, with a link to the game

- 6–9 teaser posts: Port Halden, Julian's past, "case file" style images, one detail-spotting challenge

After launch: the weekly rhythm

Day	Format	Content
Monday	Story	"Case of the week" reminder
Wednesday	Reel	The weekly hint: a short clip zooming into a clue, without giving the answer
Friday	Post	A real-life detection tip from the debriefs
Sunday	Story poll	"Who do you suspect?" for the current case

Hints posted on Instagram follow the same rule as the game: they point where to look, never at the answer. Instagram limits graphic content, so posts use evidence, documents and atmosphere rather than victims.

Risks and next steps

The biggest risk is not the code: it is writing cases that are deep, fair and consistent at scale.

Risk	What could happen	How we handle it
Case quality	Cases feel unfair, obvious or contradictory	Every case is play-tested by Reality Checker and approved by you
Volume of content	100 cases take far longer than expected	Launch with Chapter 1; release chapters over time
Art at zero budget	Characters look different between scenes	One fixed art style and a reference sheet per character
Originality	Too close to The Mentalist	Original names, story and villain; no show characters or symbols
Real-skill claims	Techniques taught are inaccurate	Base them on published methods; expert review before launch
Dark content	Store or Instagram restrictions	Restrained scenes, 16+ rating, evidence-led posts

What you need to decide next

- ☐ Approve this plan, or comment on what to change
- ☐ Approve or rename Lena Cruz, Theo Park and the Stagehand
- ☐ Say yes to starting the pilot case